

Name: _____ Section: _____
Date: _____ Score: _____

CASE STUDY

On September 29, 1982, a runny nose and sore throat signaled the beginning of a tragic medical mystery that soon shocked the world. Mary Kellerman, a 12-year-old from Chicago, disclosed her symptoms to her parents. They were unaware that one extra-strength Tylenol capsule they gave her contained highly toxic potassium cyanide. Mary passed away at 7 a.m. the following week, and her death would shake the nation.

On the same day, postal worker Adam Janus, 27, from Illinois, died of what was initially thought to be a serious heart attack but turned out to be cyanide poisoning, as well. His siblings, Stanley and Theresa, who also took Tylenol from the same bottle Adam had used earlier in the day, passed away two (2) days after.

Three additional bizarre deaths occurred over the following days: Mary McFarland, Mary Weiner of Illinois, and Paula. It turned out that each of them took Tylenol shortly before passing away.

Tylenol, the best-selling non-prescription pain reliever in the United States at the time, was linked to the deaths caused by poisoning at this point in early October 1982. Each victim took a Tylenol capsule laced with cyanide, killing them all.

McNeil Consumer Products, a subsidiary of Johnson & Johnson, produced Tylenol. The fact that the company immediately demanded a massive recall of the more than 31 million Tylenol bottles in circulation and actively participated in mass warning communications with the media is commendable. In October, contaminated capsules were discovered in a few additional drug and grocery stores in the Chicago area. The capsules had fortunately not yet been sold or consumed. Both Johnson & Johnson and McNeill offered a reward for information that led to the arrest of the person or people responsible for these random murders and replacement pills for people who turned in the pills they had already bought.

The supposed "Tylenol bill" was sanctioned by the US Congress in 1983, making it a felony to charge purchaser products. In 1989, federal guidelines were issued by the Food and Drug Administration (FDA) to ensure that none of these products could be altered.

Johnson & Johnson introduced a new kind of packaging resistant to tampering. It had foil seals and other features that made it evident to a customer if someone had done something wrong. Soon after, these packaging safeguards became the industry norm for all prescription drugs. The company also introduced price cuts and a new pill called the "caplet," coated in smooth, easy-to-swallow gelatin. It is much harder to tamper with than the older capsules, which could easily be opened, laced with a contaminant, and then put back in the older bottle that wasn't tamper-proof.

Tylenol's sales returned to their previous healthy levels within a year following an investment of more than hundreds of million. It regained its position as the nation's preferred over-the-counter pain reliever. Critics of the Tylenol brand, which had prematurely announced its demise, were now praising the company's handling of the situation. The recall of Johnson & Johnson became a well-known case study in business schools nationwide.

Questions (3 items x 10 points):

1. In your opinion, how did the Tylenol case of 1982 alter how consumers take medications?
2. What was Johnson & Johnson's responsibility and accountability to the victims when the tragedy occurred?
3. Do you think the changes made by Johnson & Johnson to the Tylenol brand are sufficient to prevent a similar incident? Explain your answer.

Rubric for grading:

CRITERIA	PERFORMANCE INDICATORS	POINTS
Content	Provided pieces of evidence, supporting details, and factual scenarios.	7
Organization of ideas	Expressed the points in a clear and logical arrangement of ideas in the paragraph.	3
Total		10

Reference:

Department of Defense. (2022). Retrieved at
<https://www.ou.edu/deptcomm/dodjcc/groups/02C2/Johnson%20&%20Johnson.htm>.